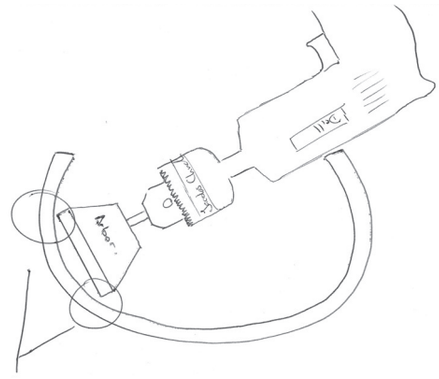
The choice here is entirely yours. For bowl work, power sanding is a good option, quickly smoothing wide, flat or flowing curves. I would just add a word of caution regarding power sanding, that if you aren't careful, it is very easy to misshape your work. An example of this is on the inside of a bowl with a tight curve, I have experienced a power sanding pad bridge the curve, rather than flexing around it, and spoiling a fluid curve to the bowl. Soft interface pads can help to avoid this, as can choosing the correct sized pad. My advice is to constantly check your progress and make sure you are achieving the results you want. For best results I will often combine hand and power sanding on bowl work. For spindle work or any fine detail work, hand sanding is the only real option.

POWER SANDING TIP:

A drill, when used for power sanding, becomes a turning tool, so just like any other tool, try to keep it in against your side and move your body for best control.

Power sanding a large bowl. Notice the drill is held against my body

Hand sanding a large bowl: notice that hand sanding is a two-handed operation



Care needs to be taken when power sanding in tight spaces

Pad size

Power sanding pads come in a variety of sizes. I would always suggest using the largest size suitable for the work in hand, so for platters with long flowing curves or chopping boards with large flat areas, go for the larger 75mm size. For tighter curves you will get better results with smaller sizes and the addition of a soft interface pad.

When hand sanding, I mostly use a rectangle of around 70mm wide, which is easily manipulated around the work, either by folding or rolling as necessary. A larger piece of abrasive is sometimes better however. For example, when sanding my walking canes, I will cut a length of abrasive, around 500mm long, so that I can cover a large area of the work, blending the surface into a smooth and straight taper.

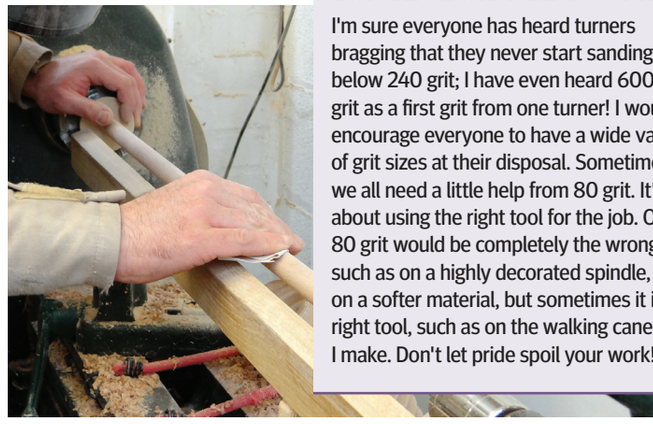
Sanding walking canes with a large strip of abrasive helps to achieve a smooth taper

Hand sanding is usually with a hand sized rectangle of abrasive

Consider sanding in line with the grain

'Flat' woodworkers will always sand in line with the grain on their work, which means that they will rarely sand finer than about 240 grit. As woodturners, we are always working across the grain, whether it be on a bowl or a spindle. That is the primary reason that we sand to such fine grits; to make those cross-grain scratches as small as possible, so that you can't see them.

On spindle work where you might have a long straight, tapered or curved section, consider sanding in line with the grain. This isn't always possible on bowl work. Any relatively wide expanses of wood will show up any flaws in your turning and sanding technique. On areas that are more highly detailed, the eye is drawn to the shapes, rather than any possible scratches, but on these long open stretches, the eye will be drawn to the smooth surface: is that a scratch? Sanding in line with the grain will remove the cross grain scratches and leave an improved surface.



Hand sanding in the direction of the grain on a walking cane, where there are no details to hide poor sanding

TOP TIP: DON'T BE TOO PROUD

I'm sure everyone has heard turners bragging that they never start sanding below 240 grit; I have even heard 600 grit as a first grit from one turner! I would encourage everyone to have a wide variety of grit sizes at their disposal. Sometimes we all need a little help from 80 grit. It's all about using the right tool for the job. Often 80 grit would be completely the wrong tool, such as on a highly decorated spindle, or on a softer material, but sometimes it is the right tool, such as on the walking canes that I make. Don't let pride spoil your work!

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